

Systems of Interpretation

Throwing the framework at the world: where it reaches, and where it gets lost.

What this part is, and is not. What follows is not an examination the framework has to pass. There is no single measurement it lives or dies by here. This is a record of something more honest and more ordinary: taking the language off its home ground and throwing it at real systems, one after another, to see where it reaches and where it quietly gets lost. A few of these attempts fit. Most of them slip. That is the point of doing them. A language earns its edges by being pushed past them, and the useful information is usually in exactly where it stops working. Read this the way it was made, as exploration, not as a verdict.

Carbon and oxygen in a dying star

The first thing thrown at it was the carbon-to-oxygen ratio left behind in white dwarfs, five of them, on the guess that the retained fraction might show up in the ash. It mostly does not. Four of the five sit nowhere near it, and for a reason worth keeping. A final abundance, frozen into a cooling star, is a record of where a process ended, not of the process while it ran. The framework's number lives in the running machine, not in what the machine leaves once it stops. Nothing broke here. The attempt simply showed which end of a system the language is allowed to be pointed at.

Reached: the method. Got lost: the target was an ending, not a running thing.

A cortex tuning itself to criticality

Next, cortical avalanches, where networks are known to tune themselves toward a critical point, in the hope that the self-regulation there would drive the continuation pressure to its golden value. Instead the two conditions turned out to be one condition wearing different clothes. At the critical point the pressure simply runs to one, which is criticality restated rather than the golden fraction discovered. The outcome was honest and clarifying. The regime was degenerate. The language had asked a real question of a system that could only answer it trivially.

Got lost: wrong regime, and cleanly diagnosed as wrong rather than fudged.

Neurons being born in a growing brain

Then some real developmental data, the leaving-fraction of dividing cells in the mouse cortex, from Takahashi and Caviness. Here the framework nearly touched something. The measured fraction reaches the retained value, and the continuation pressure reaches its golden value, but the two arrivals happen about two-thirds of a day apart, and the trajectory grazes the fixed point on its way past rather than settling onto it. A ramp, not a plateau. Close enough to feel the pull of the fixed point, not close enough to sit in it. The attempt told the framework what a genuine occupancy would have to look like, and where to go looking for one.

Reached: within a day of the mark. Got lost: the system was passing through, not resting.

A record that keeps its own balance

Which pointed straight at the last system, the adult subgranular zone, a place in the brain that goes on making new neurons at a steady balance for life. This is the regime the earlier attempts kept asking for: not a process ending, not a process ramping, but a process holding. Read one way, the standing ratio comes out near a fifth and misses. But the honest spread across defensible ways of counting runs from about a tenth to just under a third, and that band straddles the retained value, with at least one reasonable count landing inside it. So this one is left genuinely open. Not claimed, not dismissed. A single careful triple-stain count would close it either way, which is a good place for a question to be left.

Open. One clean measurement away from an answer, in either direction.

What the throwing was for

None of this is offered as proof of anything, and none of it should be. It is a map of where the language grips and where it slides. It grips on running, self-holding processes, and it slides off endings and ramps, which is exactly what a framework about self-description ought to do if it means what it says. The places

it failed are not embarrassments to be tidied out of sight. They are the part of the record that tells the shape of the tool, and so they are kept here, in the encyclopedia of records, where honest results belong.